



GOA MARCHING TO A GREENER FUTURE

Development walks hand-in-hand with the needs of the "aam admi" in the progressive state of Goa. To mark one year of the Congress led Digambar Kamat government, a tribute to this coastal retreat which has turned into a global destination.

Not just tourists but even entrepreneurs from all over the world have been making a beeline for this enticing paradise on earth. There is evidence of growth everywhere - in the burgeoning five-star properties and boutique hotels targeted at the well-heeled traveller, in the gourmet restaurants that do brisk business all year round, in the bustling stores and marketplaces, in the growing pharma and IT industry, in the feverish pace of professionals who scurry around busily despite the chilled-out air of sosegado.

Goa can be a heady cocktail of business and pleasure. But Goans love their land and don't want it swamped by indiscriminate growth. In deference to the wishes of the people of Goa who began to agitate against it, the Regional Development Plan 2010 that had been prepared earlier was scrapped and the government initiated action towards framing a new one that would take into confidence all the stakeholders. A task force of eminent architects and renowned town planners like Charles Correa and Edgar Ribeiro has been set up, and Goa *Bachao Abhiyan* (the organization that spearheaded the agitation) was given representation. Since the experts are all Goans with an enduring love for their beloved state, the new regional plan is expected to work towards fulfilling the aspirations of the common man.

The government is working tirelessly to encourage Private Public Participation (PPP), so that the private sector can have a stake in the development of Goa by investing in big projects that cannot be completely funded by the State. But in deference again to the wishes of the people, the Chief Minister Digambar Kamat, always the people's man, has scrapped all SEZs in the state.

International Film Festival of India (IFFI), GOA

Goa is the permanent venue for the International Film Festival of India. The festival is organized by the Entertainment Society of Goa (ESG) jointly with I & B Ministry, Govt of India. The ESG will be taking over the festival in the coming years with active organization of support from the Indian Film Industry. The ESG is striving hard to promote Goa as an International Entertainment hub and a committee has been formed under



the Chairmanship of renowned film maker Shekhar Kapur to further this objective. The government has also evolved new film-based schemes to involve the local people and for them to imbibe a film culture.

Ideal Investment Destination

Tourism along with mining has become the main thrust area for economic growth in Goa. There are other industries like the pharmaceuticals industry that are showing great potential too, so Verna in South Goa is being developed as a pharma hub. Information Technology (IT) and entertainment industries are also being encouraged, as they produce jobs in a pleasant and non-polluting environment that is best suited to the Goan temperament.

Goa is the first and only state in the country to have its own cultural policy, which was drafted by taking all sections of society into confidence. There is a gurukul system in place whereby artists who don't have financial resources can apply to the state for assistance. Those artists in distress due to a medical emergency or old age can make use of the Kalakar Welfare Fund. On Teachers' Day last year, the government announced its decision to grant secondary and higher secondary teachers loans to buy laptops.

Boost for the arts: the newly inaugurated Ravindra Bhavan in Margao

